

Title EU Operation Overload targets academics, law enforcement

07/04/2025

Summary

- Through the first three months of 2025, the Kremlin-aligned influence operation (IO) known as Operation Overload or Matryoshka circulated at least 134 pieces of content on X, including 118 videos, eight fake news headlines, and two images of fake graffiti. More than 40% of those videos used AI tools to manipulate real videos of academics, law enforcement officers, and others to make it appear as if they made false or inflammatory comments.
- The IO's narratives range broadly, touching on elections, political developments, economic issues, terrorism, and the war in Ukraine, among other topics.
- The IO is causing severe reputational risk to those whose videos and voices are being manipulated.
- Operation Overload develops video-based content, co-opts videos from trusted sources, manipulates those videos to seed distortions, and uses bots to flood the information space.
- Individuals and institutions inadvertently used to propagate Operation Overload's content should be contacted, potentially through law enforcement or oversight bodies.

Incident

Between January 1 and March 31, 2025, Operation Overload circulated at least 134 pieces of content on X, including 118 videos and eight fake newspaper headlines, to foster tension within NATO states and undermine support for Ukraine.

Half of that content involved some form of media impersonation. Twenty-eight media organisations were impersonated. DW's branding was appropriated 15 times, making it the most mimicked outlet. Nearly 25% of content impersonated academics, with 29 universities (mainly in France and the UK) being targeted. The IO also targeted law enforcement, unions, politicians, and celebrities. Ten countries and the EU were targeted, with the operation focusing roughly half of its content on Germany, likely because of the recent federal elections.

More than 40% of the 118 videos used AI tools to manipulate real videos of academics, law enforcement officers, and others to make it appear as if they made false or inflammatory comments. Of those videos, nearly 60% manipulated videos of academics, making them appear as if they had praised terrorist attacks, offered money for the removal of heads of state, and criticised Ukraine, among other things.

Narrative

Meta narrative: NATO countries are unsafe, unstable, and should not help Ukraine

Sub-narratives: Ukrainian refugees are a threat; Ukraine is draining resources for domestic programs; Europe is not prepared for military conflict; Emmanuel Macron should be removed; the AfD will save Germany

Impact

Reach: A large bot network was responsible for the overwhelming majority of engagements with posts on X. A sample of posts over the last three months averaged 62,000 views, 192 reposts, and 385 likes, however, previous research on Operation Overload found all of its engagement to be artificially driven.

Outcome: No real-life impacts have been reported, however here is potential for severe reputational risk to those whose videos and voices have been manipulated. There is also potential for narratives to enter the mainstream if influential accounts promote them.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0079](#): Divided users by spreading politically contentious disinformation

Objective: [T0140.001](#): Defamed individuals by making it appear as if they said false or inflammatory things

[T0087](#) – Developed video-based content to spread disinformation about political, economic, and security issues

[T0100.001](#) – Co-opted trusted individuals by manipulating videos of academics, law enforcement, and others

[T0044](#) – Seeded distortions by making it appear as if trusted sources made statements they did not say

[T0049.003](#) – Used bots to flood the information space

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: None to date.

Recommendations: Contact individuals and institutions that have been inadvertently used to propagate Operation Overload's disinformation, potentially through law enforcement or oversight bodies;
Report content to X.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
	Russia	<u>Observables</u> <u>Spreadsheet</u>	Institute for Strategic Dialogue	X	